flush out this poison, but India is intrinsically an inclusive country and Hinduism is at its best a generous religion ("*udaar charitaanaam tu vasudhaiva kutumbakam*"), so yes, there is hope, though possibly not in my lifetime.

Q. How did you earn your reputation as a media-shy recluse? Would you describe yourself as an introvert (although you did speak out quite publicly against Section 377)?

I think I'm rather a gregarious recluse. I spend a lot of time on my own, but I enjoy meeting my family and friends—and usually have a good time at a party. It's true, I'm media-shy. I don't feel I need to make pronouncements on every random subject in order to fill the media's maw. Besides, I'm not sure my opinion is more valuable than that of any other reasonably well-informed citizen. Yes, I have spoken out occasionally in public—on the apartheid murder of Steve Biko, on the Tiananmen Square massacre, on the destruction of the Babri Masjid, on the silence of high government officials with regard to the murderous cow-mobs, on the two-judge Supreme Court decision (in 2013) to recriminalise homosexuality.

With regard to this last, it was very encouraging when a five-judge constitutional bench of the Supreme Court overruled this in 2018. And with regard to the recent and related matter of marriage equality before a different five-judge constitutional bench, I believe that they will not prevaricate with intermediate solutions in the interests of political palatability, but will come to the only just, logical and humane decision.

Q. The sequel to *A Suitable Boy* is eagerly awaited. When can readers hope to get their hands on a copy?

I too eagerly await it—I am keen to know what happens. But each time I state a completion date, it whizzes past. I'd better not do that again. *A Suitable Girl* is certainly on its way, but at a time of her choosing.

Q. Do you travel or are you a home bird?

In my youth, I hitchhiked across Tibet. In middle age, I sailed from Svalbard to Greenland. Now, I sit in my *barsati* and sip green tea.

Q. Do you have the time to pursue other interests apart from writing? And what might those be?

I love singing, painting, calligraphy, swimming (no matter how warm or cold the water) and sleep (because I have interesting dreams). But I hardly have time for any of these, including the last, because *Girl* and her attendant novellas occupy most of my hours. ■

with Amit Dixit

BOOKS

The Political Poet

A new edition of **Shrikant Verma**'s *Magadh* puts the spotlight back on a classic

The rich folk culture of the Narmada region produced an astonishing array of poets and writers. Vinod Kumar Shukla, currently the toast of Hindi poetry, is from Raipur in Chhattisgarh. Nearby Bilaspur is where Shrikant Verma was born in 1931. His verse had the ready lyricism of the regional idiom.

Verma was an exception, however, in several ways. A successful journalist in the 1960s, he became an MP in 1976, during the Emergency, and was a close advisor to Indira Gandhi. Verma's catchy slogans helped revive her political career.

Though the poems are set in ancient cities, you can never be sure Verma isn't talking current affairs

Yet, the Narmada inside Verma did not dry up on the banks of the Yamuna. His last major compilation of poems in 1984 was titled *Magadh*; he died of cancer two years later. The poems are a majestic assault on political power. If the epic form celebrates the state, wars, bravery and classical culture, *Magadh* is an epic unravelling of these. The dystopic wasteland on the other side of utopia!

The poems are set in ancient cities like Pataliputra and Kashi. But you can never be sure Verma isn't talking current affairs. Fiction, history, non-fiction...everything mashed up into a timeless depiction of the human condition. The insanity of *Magadh* seems like Verma's attempt to retain his sanity in Delhi's political hustle.

A new edition of Rahul Soni's 2013 translation has just been released. Soni encountered *Magadh* in 2007 and "started translating it almost immediately, before I had even finished reading the collection". It's difficult to imagine *Magadh* being translated any other way. It has to be visceral, a compulsion that doesn't quit.

The task is complicated. *Magadh* was composed in masterly free verse that has a cascading rhythm, for Verma was equally adept at rhyme. To Soni's credit, those who have read the Hindi original will not feel shortchanged. Those who don't read Hindi are in for a treat. Buy this one. You'll read it over and over again. You'll need it in this age of the Anthropocene. ■

Sopan Joshi



MAGADH
By Shrikant Verma
EKA (WESTLAND)
₹599;
144 pages